Introduction

India is a land of mystery, richness, and deep spiritual discovery. Every facet of this ancient land seems scented with the famous spices that lured European traders to its shores more than five centuries ago. Here, Muslims, Hindus, Christians, Sikhs, and Buddhists live shoulder to shoulder in a crowded world of multiple gods and juxtaposed pilgrimage routes, each one perfectly peaceful in their own beliefs and traditions.

More than one billion people live on the Indian subcontinent, working in a range of industries that begins in the agricultural sector and ends in the high-tech business world of Delhi. Intensified manufacturing and digital technologies have brought modern India into the global market, trading in communications software, customer service, and IT management—but these are far from the technologies and industries that put this ancient land on every map. Long before the British Raj or the tea trade, India was beloved for its spices and jewels. For much of history, India provided the majority of the world's diamonds from its own mines. Some of those sparkling, perfect gems grace the likes of the British crown jewels.

Cinnamon, cardamom, turmeric, silks, and textiles remain at the forefront of the Indian market, while the country's cities embrace office work in the form of healthcare, insurance, and banking administration. Where now there are 21st-century business clothes and high-rises, once there were only religious robes and fish markets. In India, however, modernity need not take the place of antiquity; in the many cities and towns of the subcontinent, traditionally robed monks walk the streets chanting their spells alongside a parade in honor of the Hindu God Shiva, while a block away hundreds of English-speaking Indians set down their briefcases and log onto the internet to begin the day's work.

India is quite unique in the way it has brought its ancient histories and traditions with it into the modern age. Ganesh and Shiva have accompanied their people from the Indus River Valley–the spring of Indian civilization–down the Ganges and forward through time.